Demo Guide

Judges will see a short demo, not your feature list. This guide covers the story, the script, who does what, and what to do when something breaks.

The pitch (memorize this)

Hook (10 sec): "The best way to learn a language is immersion, but most of us can't move abroad, and the media in other languages is hard to watch. What if you could learn from the stuff you already watch?"

Product (one line): "Our Chrome extension turns any YouTube video into a language lesson, with color-matched bilingual captions, instant pronunciation from ElevenLabs, and a dashboard that tracks your accent improving over time."

Tagline: *Speak it, track it, improve it.*

Demo script (about 2 minutes)

Time	Step	What to do	What to say
0:00	**Hook**	Slide or face-to-face, no screen yet	The problem and the hook above
0:10	**Captions**	Open a popular English YouTube video, toggle the extension on	"Watch the captions. Same video, but now in Spanish."
0:25	**Color pairs**	Point to the overlay	"'How' matches 'cómo.' 'Are you' matches 'estás.' Word order differs between languages, so Gemini aligns by meaning, not position."

0:40	**Click and hear**	Click a word, sidebar opens, play pronunciation	"Click any word for an explanation, and ElevenLabs says it aloud."
0:50	**Shadow a line**	Hit record, repeat the line, show the score and the highlighted missed word	"Now you say it. We transcribe with ElevenLabs Scribe and show exactly which word you missed."
1:10	**Live dashboard**	Switch to the dashboard. The attempt just appeared in the trend chart	"That attempt just landed in Tiger Data, and the chart updated live."
1:25	**Depth**	Show trouble words and the study heatmap	"These are served from continuous aggregates, with compression on older data, so they stay instant even with hundreds of thousands of events."
1:45	**Close**	Back to the pitch	"Learn from the media you already watch, and see yourself improve."

Rules:

- Every step should take under 15-20 seconds.
- One person talks, one person drives. Don't both reach for the keyboard.
- Show the color pairing slowly. It is the most memorable visual.
- Pause one beat after the live dashboard update so judges see it happen.

Sponsor-specific talking points

Judges for sponsor tracks often visit separately. Have a 30-second version ready for each.

ElevenLabs (earbuds)

- We use **more than one product**: Text-to-Speech for pronunciation and slow mode, and Scribe speech-to-text for shadowing.
- Audio makes the learning **interactive**: you hear it, you say it, you get feedback. It is not a play button.

- Audio is cached by text + voice + speed, so repeats are instant.
- If built: the conversational voice tutor for chatting about the video.

Tiger Data (Stream Deck Mini)

- Every lookup and shadowing attempt is a **time-series event** in a hypertable.
- Relational data (users, vocab) and time-series data live **side by side in one database**.
- **Continuous aggregates** power the dashboard so it stays instant at scale.
- **Compression** keeps lots of events on a free-tier instance.
- Be upfront: bulk history is synthetic seed data, and the live attempt is real.

Gemini API (swag kits)

- Gemini does the heavy lifting: **meaning-based alignment** of captions into color-coded pairs, grammar and culture notes, and (if built) the weekly summary.
- Structured JSON output drives the UI directly.

Best AI Hack

- The project is built around models: LLM alignment and explanation, plus speech-to-text for scoring.

Roles for the demo

Role	Person	Job
Presenter	Whoever is strongest at speaking	Delivers the pitch and narrates
Driver	Extension lead	Runs the browser and the extension
Dashboard + backup	Person C	Runs the dashboard, watches the backend, switches to the backup video if needed

Team members should each be ready to take the presenter role if another judge group arrives while someone is away.

Pre-demo checklist

Do this 30 minutes before judging, and again before each sponsor visit.

- Laptop charged and plugged in
- Backend running and responding (`/events` and `/tts` test calls)
- Tiger Data connected, dashboard loads
- Extension loaded and updated to the latest build
- Demo video opened, captions already pre-translated and cached
- Microphone permission granted and tested in the actual room (noise matters)
- Volume turned up, audio output tested
- Browser zoom and window size set so text is readable from a few feet away
- Notifications and unrelated tabs closed
- Backup demo video open in another tab
- Wifi checked, with a phone hotspot as a backup
- API key credits and rate limits checked

When something breaks (plan B)

Failure	Plan B
Wifi drops	Switch to the phone hotspot. If that fails, play the backup demo video and narrate.
Caption extraction fails on the video	Use the cached demo video. Do not try a new video live.
Gemini is slow or rate limited	Use the pre-translated cache for the demo video.
Microphone does not work	Show a pre-recorded shadowing attempt, or fall back to the backup video for that step.
ElevenLabs fails	Play pre-cached audio for the demo words.

Dashboard shows nothing	Use seed data. Say, "This is the seeded history," and show the trend.
Everything fails	Play the backup demo video, narrate it, and explain the architecture from a slide.

Rule: never debug in front of a judge. Switch to plan B, smile, and keep talking.

Backup demo video

- Record it during the freeze window (hours 28-32), after the demo script runs cleanly.
- Capture the full flow with voice narration.
- Keep it under 2 minutes. Save it locally and upload it to the submission.
- Keep a copy on a phone and in the cloud in case a laptop dies.

Devpost submission checklist

- **Project name and tagline** ("Speak it, track it, improve it")
- **Short description:** problem, solution, who it is for
- **Backup demo video** uploaded
- **Screenshots or GIF:** colored captions, sidebar, shadowing score, dashboard
- **"How we built it":** the architecture diagram plus the tech stack
- **ElevenLabs section:** explicitly name TTS, Scribe STT, slow mode, and caching
- **Tiger Data section:** explicitly name hypertable, continuous aggregates, compression, and relational + time-series side by side
- **Gemini section:** meaning-based alignment, structured output, and notes
- **Challenges we ran into:** alignment quality, microphone access, latency
- **What we learned**
- **What's next:** Netflix support, more languages, reverse mode, spaced repetition, voice tutor
- **Track selection:** select every track we are eligible for (Best Overall, Best AI, ElevenLabs, Gemini, Tiger Data, and Best First Time Hack if we qualify)
- **Repo link:** public, with a README and a `.env.example`, and with no keys committed
- **Promo code and sponsor requirements:** claimed and noted if sponsors ask
- Submit **early**, then keep polishing

Anticipated judge questions

Question	Answer
How does the alignment work?	Gemini aligns by meaning with structured output, so word order and idioms are handled. A pair can be a phrase.
How accurate is the pronunciation score?	It is intelligibility scoring. We score what Scribe heard against the target, a strong proxy, not a phonetic analysis.
Why Tiger Data instead of plain Postgres?	Hypertables, continuous aggregates, and compression keep the dashboard instant as events grow, and we keep relational and time-series data in one database.
Is the dashboard data real?	Live attempts are real. The history is a synthetic seed to show trends.
Why not Netflix?	DRM and custom subtitle delivery. It is on the roadmap. YouTube proves the pipeline.
Does it work for other languages?	The pipeline is language-agnostic because Gemini handles it. We tuned and tested Spanish.
What if a video has no captions?	We fall back to the live caption element, or notify the user. Pre-translation requires a transcript.
How is this different from Language Reactor?	We focus on color-aligned phrase pairs, speaking practice with scoring, and a progress dashboard on top of the media you already watch.

What about API cost and privacy?	Keys stay in the backend. Audio is only sent for transcription when the user records.

Final rehearsal checklist

- Run the full demo at least 3 times with a timer
- Practice the 30-second sponsor versions
- Practice each plan B once, especially the backup video switch
- Assign who answers which judge question
- Sleep and eat before the final judging